SYEDA TAWHEEDA HUQ

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Sources and evaluates pre-seed founders for Entrepreneurs First and Girls Into VC; 5 sourced founders are now in pre-seed discussions. Researching whether the AI tools investors use to screen founders reproduce bias.

EDUCATION

Lehigh University | B.S. Cognitive Science (AI Track) *Expected May 2027*
Minors: Corporate Entrepreneurship; Theatre Production **Relevant coursework:** Finance 101 · Behavioral Statistics
Honors: 2× R.K. Laros Endowed Prize for Creativity, Innovation & Entrepreneurship · Lehigh Future Maker 2026 (senior honor society for startup & innovation work) · Featured on NASDAQ Tower, Times Square
Leadership: Program Lead, Lehigh AI Club · International Orientation Leader (2024, 2025)

EXPERIENCE

Investment Fellow, Talent Investing | Entrepreneurs First *Jul 2026 – Present*
- Sourced and warm-introduced 10 pre-seed and seed founders across NYC and Philadelphia (raising under $500K to ~$2M), often before there was a product or cofounder to assess
- 5 escalated to EF partners and are now in the pipeline for EF's Bridge residency
- Bridge under-networked talent communities into EF's pipeline; hosted founder events in NYC, including a summer Matcha & Mahjong founder mixer

VC Scout | Girls Into VC (GIVC) *Sep 2026 – Present*
- Source founders at founder and fundraising events across Philadelphia, NYC and Boston and at GIVC's national summit
- Write memos using bottom-up unit economics and TAM/SAM/SOM sizing; refer fintech, healthtech and B2B founders to GIVC partners and funds (Shakti VC, Small World Capital, Two Lantern VC, Kickstart Ventures)
- 5 sourced founders have cleared screening and are in active pre-seed deal discussions

Business & Sales Development Intern | Sway (two-sided venue marketplace, San Francisco Bay Area) *May – Dec 2025*
- Rebuilt the venue-owner segment and partnership model for a marketplace matching restaurants, golf clubs and event spaces across the Bay Area with hosts; diagnosed churn as a trust problem and connected venues directly with hosts
- Brokered venue-to-venue partnerships to drive retention, e.g. paired Temple Bar with a virtual cocktail bar to co-host a curated event for Sway hosts
- Rebuilt client onboarding end to end, automating 300+ weekly intakes and cutting manual handling ~65%

BUILDING: VENTURE PROGRAMS & PRODUCTS

Founder | Women in VC Platform → WeRise Cohort (Soar With Us Fellowship) *Aug 2025 – Present*
- Built a platform across three Lehigh departments giving underrepresented and women founders direct pipelines to investors and mentors; now part of the national GIVC network
- Grew it into WeRise (Feb 2026), a cohort of 8 women founders funded by Lehigh's Office of Entrepreneurship; sourced one founder into the GIVC Summit pitch competition
- Ran VC simulation workshops on thesis, competitive landscape and deal structuring for 15 student founders

Head Fellow & Advisory Head | Baker Institute for Entrepreneurship *Aug 2026 – Present*
- Proposed and launched a Baker fellowship and serve as its Fellows' Chair, leading 7 student mentors in a year-long redesign of Hatchery, EUREKA and LehighSiliconValley

Program Lead & Founding Facilitator | Hatchery Program, Baker Institute *Aug 2023 – Present*
- Co-built a YC-style cohort and the Hatchery → EUREKA → Lehigh Valley Grand Pitch pipeline; 200+ students engaged, one participant accepted to Y Combinator

RESEARCH: HOW AI MAKES DECISIONS ABOUT PEOPLE

AI Bias in Venture Deal Allocation | Senior Capstone *2026 – Present*
- Building a system to test whether the LLM diligence tools VC firms use screen founders on demographic and institutional signals; interviewing founders and investors on how screening decisions get made

Course Grader, CSE 252: AI and Computing Ethics | Lehigh University *Two semesters, current*
- Grade undergraduate work on algorithmic fairness, model accountability and AI governance

Research Assistant | Cognitive Science Research Lab, Lehigh University *Fall 2024 – Spring 2025*
- Year-long study with the department chair on how memory and attention shape decisions in a gamified environment

TOOLS

Clay · Airtable · Notion · Figma · Replit · Zapier · PitchBook · Crunchbase